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THEORISING THE SILENCES

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Michel-Rolph Trouillot, who wrote on the liberation struggle of the slaves of Haiti, was the pioneering writer on archival silences. For Trouillot, silences were inherent in the writing of history and in the creation of archives. Sometimes, they were the things left out, not deliberately but because they were not seen as important at the time. He argued that silences are created at four central moments: the moment of fact creation (the making of sources); the moment of fact assembly (the making of archives); the moment of fact retrieval (the making of narratives); and the moment of retrospective significance (the making of history in the final instance).[1]

He used the example of the Haitian liberation struggle. There are very few sources in France describing the views of the revolutionaries because the European intelligentsia could not conceive of the idea of a black republic and believed that the revolt was caused by outside agitators. This disdain for the revolutionaries has continued almost to our day, the British historian Eric Hobsbawm scarcely mentions Haiti in his book *The Age of Revolutions, 1789–1843*. Trouillot said 'What we are observing here is archival power at its strongest, the power to define what is and what is not a serious object of research and therefore of mention'.[2]

We fully accept Trouillot's theorising of archival silences, but, in this chapter, we wish to add some glosses to it, which, while not taking away from his essential argument, offer a more in-depth view.

When we first began thinking about silences, we assumed that silences in archives are always present and that users are normally correct in asserting that evidence is missing. We also believed that the ending of silences – the discovery or release of previously silenced archives – would have a healing effect. We also accepted the common trope that the marginalised are most likely to suffer from silences. In fact, the situation is much more nuanced than we originally thought. Although all those statements are true, they are only true up to a point.

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What we have discovered is just how visceral and political archival silences can be, but that the ending of silences does not always solve anything. Moreover, we are increasingly aware of the issues posed by the textuality of archives. The issue of which is the 'original' of a record that has long troubled manuscript and biblical scholars will surely come to trouble archive users in the digital age. Digitisation is silencing records because scholars at wealthy universities in the north have access to a diversity of material unavailable to scholars at poorer universities in the south. At the same time, digitisation programmes may mean that records that are non-western, non-canonical and non-quotidian are excluded, thus continuing to silence the poor and marginalised.

Finally, we are increasingly aware that silences mean silences. That archival practices have turned records that were intended to be spoken out loud – to be performed – into texts to be read silently and by so doing have robbed them of much of their meaning. This is particularly the case with evidence presented in courts of law that was either given by those involved or was in the form of depositions.

Silences only exist when researchers in the archives notice them

Silences only come into existence when researchers look for specific pieces of information in the archive. Until then, they are uncreated and potential rather than actual. When Richard W. Pollay, historian and paper and advertising collector, first began studying the archives of the advertising industry and marketing ephemera in the mid-1970s, he remarked on the archival silences. Apart from limited collections at the New York Public Library and the US Library of Congress, there was very little material available to researchers.[3]

It is important to be nuanced in thinking about silences and not jump to any conclusions without considering all possibilities. Many silences could be avoided by a more determined approach by creators and archivists and a more liberal attitude by governments. The availability of archives of advertising has been totally transformed since Pollay made his complaint in the 1970s. A combination of better catalogues, more digitisation, greater interest in the study of advertising and marketing and the donation of material to archives means both that more records are available and that there is greater awareness of their availability. Indeed, it seems that, even at the time he was writing, the situation was not as bad as Pollay described.[4]

Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence

While Pollay was quite reasonable in his expectations, the fact that a user believes that there is a gap or silence in the archives may not necessarily be true. It could be an example of confirmation bias. This form of cognitive bias was defined by Nickerson as the 'seeking or interpreting of evidence in ways that are partial to existing beliefs, expectations, or a hypothesis in hand'.[5] Nickerson cites the example of the British expedition to West Africa in 1919 to take advantage of a solar eclipse

to test Einstein's theory that light would be bent by a gravitational field. The evidence taken by the expedition was noisy and its leader, Arthur Eddington, had to decide which photographs to use. He took his decision on the basis of Einstein's theory, leading to the paradoxical situation that Eddington could only claim to have confirmed Einstein because he used Einstein's derivations in deciding what his observations really were, while Einstein's derivations only became accepted because Eddington's observation seemed to confirm them.[6]

An example of confirmation bias is, perhaps, Naomi Wolf's reading of the Old Bailey records. In her book *Outrages: Sex, Censorship and the Criminalisation of Love*, Wolf sought to show that 'modern homophobia' was born in 1857, when the introduction of the Matrimonial Causes Act made sodomy a threat to marriage. On a BBC Radio programme she claimed to have discovered several dozen executions of men for having sex with other men. The Old Bailey records show such cases with the phrase 'death recorded'. In fact, this phrase was a piece of legal jargon that had been introduced in 1823, which allowed judges to abstain from pronouncing a sentence of death on anyone they considered suitable for a pardon and it appears that no men were executed for this crime in the period under discussion.[7]

The ending of silences does not always resolve issues

In his article on archives as spaces of memory, Eric Ketelaar discusses the role of archives in truth, justice and memory.[8] While there are many cases of people being helped to find some sort of closure by the release of previously silent archives, this is not the inevitable outcome. The power of archives to prevent tragedies or to heal in highly conflicted situations is limited. At a conference at Northumbria University on 24 November 2015, Onora O'Neill said 'Do not imagine better record keeping will solve all this, it will not'. Equally, while the Independent Panel on Hillsborough revealed most of the hidden records of the tragedy and helped the families of victims, it did not bring closure. The report was followed by a further coroner's inquest and attempts to prosecute senior police officers involved.

The dispute over the so called 'Comfort Women' was equally visceral and wrapped in archival silences. However, the eventual discovery of relevant records did not resolve the issue. The story of the 'Comfort Women' was described by Chien Liu.

> During World War II, the Japanese military recruited 50,000 to 200,000 women, with varying degrees of coercion and deception, from its colonized and occupied territories into sexual slavery for Japanese troops. It has been estimated that Koreans made up about 80–90% of comfort women; the others were from Taiwan, China, the Philippines, Indonesia, the Netherlands, and Australia. The most common method of 'recruitment' was to deceive women with false promises of employment in Japan. The comfort women endured tremendous agonies under inhumane conditions, suffering from mental anguish, sexually transmitted diseases, and violence from soldiers. At the end

> of the war, many of them were abandoned or killed by retreating Japanese troops; some were forced to commit suicide along with the soldiers.[9]

Probably between a quarter and a third of the women survived. When they returned home, they were too afraid to speak, fearing that if they did so, they would be ostracised from their families and society.[10]

The Japanese military destroyed most of the records relating to these women and so, for many decades, archival silence meant that the truth of what happened was covered up. In 1988, the Korean Church Women's Association began to press for action on this matter. In 1991, Kim-Hak-sun, angered at the Japanese refusal to admit what had happened or to issue an apology became the first Korean former comfort woman to speak out. It was the very archival silence that led to her decision. The Korean Council for Women Drafted for Sexual Slavery had written to the Japanese Embassy demanding an apology. The embassy had replied that a government investigation had found no evidence that women had been forced into slavery and so no apology could be issued. Kim-Hak-sun had been kidnapped at the age of 17 and sent to a Japanese army unit.[11]

In January 1992, the historian Yoshimi Yoshiaki found, in the Japanese Defence Agency's National Institute of Defense Studies, documents, including one called *Matters Concerning the Recruitment of Women to Work in Military Comfort Stations*, which was sent on 4 March 1938, by an adjutant in the Japanese War Ministry to the Chiefs of Staff of the North China Area Army and the Central China Expeditionary Force. These documents clearly demonstrated that the Japanese military were involved in the establishment of so-called comfort stations and the recruitment of women as sex slaves to work in them.[12]

The Japanese government issued an apology in 1993, the so-called Kono document, which recognised the Japanese military's role in coercive recruitment and transfer of 'Comfort Women' and in the establishment and management of the comfort stations, accepted the moral responsibility of the Japanese government and apologised to the victims.

It is at this point that we run into the limits of the role of archives in promoting social justice, because the issue of social justice rapidly moved from a debate about archival facts to one about politics.

Although the Japanese government issued an apology, this did not settle the issue because, it only accepted moral, not legal, responsibility and it refused compensation. Instead, it set up a private foundation, the Asia Women's Foundation, to compensate the surviving victims.[13] Right-wing Japanese politicians began to deny the Japanese government's involvement in mobilising the 'Comfort Women' and this view was supported by Japanese Prime Minister, Shinzo Abe in 2007.[14]

Abe's denial damaged relationships between South Korea and Japan and it was not until 2015 that President Obama, as part of his pivot to Asia sought to achieve a reconciliation. His aim was to achieve a resolution of the 'Comfort Women' issue and to secure a trilateral security arrangement between the US, Japan and South Korea. The Japanese government admitted the involvement of their military in the

'Comfort Women' issue and agreed to contribute $8.3 million to a fund to support the surviving women. However, they still did not admit legal responsibility. This was as good a deal as could be got and both sides declared the matter closed. A year later, on her return from a reconciliation visit to Pearl Harbor, Japanese Defence Minister, Tomomi Inada, visited the Yasukuni Shrine, a traditional Japanese militarist centre where 14 class A war criminals are enshrined. It rapidly became clear that the 'Comfort Women' matter had not been resolved to the wishes of ordinary people in South Korea.[15]

Archives relating to 'Comfort Women' were a significant source of contention between China and Japan at the meeting of the Advisory Committee of the UNESCO Memory of the World Register in 2015. The Register was established in 1992 and was originally concerned with documents at risk. It is now a list of significant documents for global history. We despair at this approach, having moved away from the 'great man' view of history, we are now being pushed towards a 'great documents' view of history. As Ian Wilson, former Librarian and Archivist of Canada observed: 'Creeping politicization has underlined the impact of documentary heritage on national historical narratives and identities'.[16]

At a time of rising tension between China and Japan, China sought to have two collections of records added to the register: papers concerning the episode of mass murder and mass rape by Japanese imperial troops in Nanjing, China in 1937–1938 and a collection of papers relating to Chinese women used as 'Comfort Women' by Japanese troops. There was a furious row between China and Japan over these two collections of archives, with the Japanese government threatening to withdraw funding from UNESCO. Eventually, while the Nanjing papers were added to the register, the 'Comfort Women' papers were not. China was instructed to co-ordinate with other countries which might be considering submitting documents on the same subject.[17]

The dispute over the Nanjing and 'Comfort Women' archives demonstrates clearly the intensely political nature of archives and their limits in resolving historical issues. The release of previously silenced records does not necessarily ensure resolution or reconciliation.

The marginalised are not the only ones to suffer from silences

It is a well-known trope in current archival writing that marginalised groups are excluded from archives. Writing in 2018, Rebekah Xanthe Taylor and Craig Jordan-Baker said that 'Authors looking at marginalized groups specifically, emphasize that archives of more marginalized groups may not be created in the first place and more formal institutional archives might speak about marginalized groups only in statistics and diversity monitoring'.[18]

This is true, but the situation is more nuanced. Certainly, many marginalised groups do not appear in records. It is, for example, hard to find information about Roma and other travellers, particularly in early periods, while there is little or

nothing about individual slaves who were shipped across the Atlantic to America or the Caribbean.

However, in England at least, it is not just marginalised groups who do not appear in records Most people do not feature much in them until the twentieth century. Writing in the language of the 1960s, historian A.J.P. Taylor said 'a sensible law-abiding Englishman could pass through life and hardly notice the existence of the state beyond the post office and the policeman. He could live where he liked and as he liked'.[19] As Simon Fowler observed, 'Until World War I, records in the western world were largely created for or about the very rich or the very poor'.[20] The rich paid taxes, bought and sold property, got involved in litigation of various sorts and kept household accounts.

The poor fell outside the tax net and for most people in England, the only records of their lives were those kept by the church and later by the state of their births, marriages and deaths. From 1841, they began to appear in census records. They might have lived in a cottage that was part of a manor and so appeared in a court roll, or they might have had other brushes with the civil, criminal or church courts. Some might have held local offices or won prizes at flower shows and so might be traceable through digitised local newspapers. But it is very hard to trace information about many who existed above the poverty level. One of us (Thomas) has spent time trying to track the career of the writer Frederic Martyn who wrote a fictitious account of his adventures in the French Foreign Legion. Beyond Martyn's highly romanticised published versions of his life, very little survives beyond census records and details of his military career, although he lived until the 1930s. A later section of this chapter tells of Thomas Holden who was transported to Australia at the end of the Napoleonic wars. He subsequently returned to England but we know nothing of Holden's life after he achieved liberty.[21] Neither Martyn nor Holden were marginalised people – Martyn was a sergeant-major in the British army, while Holden was a weaver – a semi-literate artisan.

The very poorest people can be found in the voluminous records concerned with poor relief. Those who joined the British army from 1869 onwards were part of an organisation that marched on forms. The 1880 *Classified List and Alphabetical Index of Army Forms and List of Army Books* included 1285 forms and every soldier made an appearance in a number of these. Indeed, as Barrett and Stallybrass have argued, the presence of so many forms required people to fill them in and so the army, which recruited from the poorest people in society, became a forcing house for literacy. But for most people in earlier times, the archives are more or less silent.[22]

It was ever thus. Sometime between and 450 and 180 BCE, somebody known to biblical scholars as Kohelet wrote:

> And some there be, which have no memorial; who are perished, as though they had never been; and are become as though they had never been born; and their children after them.[23]

Silencing has been part of government's policies for millennia

In 2019, Arthur Bradley of Lancaster University cast a new light on silences. Taking his cue from a lecture by Michel Foucault, he argued that sovereignty is neither the power to make die and let live (as the ancient Roman formula puts it) nor the power to make live and let die (as Foucault's reversal of the Roman dictum puts it) but the power to make neither live nor die. He argues that sovereign power can be used to decide what counts as being alive and, by using exile, expulsion, proscription, non-recognition, social death, pre-emptive or retroactive nullification, it can reduce people to a state where it is as if they never existed.[24]

The earliest example cited by Bradley is the Roman practice whereby any emperor who had brought disgrace or discredit on the state, or any citizen who committed treason could be subject to *damnatio memoriae* whereby all traces of their existence were removed. For emperors (such as Geta in AD 211), their names were scratched from inscriptions on tablets, their faces chiselled from statues, their temples destroyed, images on coins defaced, wills annulled and property expropriated.[25]

Bradley goes on to trace this practice through history, including the Gunpowder Plot, which, according to Attorney General [later Lord Chief Justice] Edward Coke, was an attempt to achieve the death of the king; 'and not the death of the king only, but of his whole kingdom … even the deletion of our whole name and nation'.[26] Bradley also argues that the decision by the Red Army to kill the entire Romanov family and not just the Czar in May 1919 was part of this practice. It had to be made as if the Romanovs had never existed.[27]

Putting people in the same invisible position as the Emperor Geta continues to be an element of modern policy. Bradley has argued that the enforced or involuntary disappearances in Chile, Argentina and Guatemala prefigure the USA's use of extraordinary rendition and use of secret detention centres.[28]

Damnatio memoriae is still going strong. Following the disclosure of allegations of child abuse by the late entertainer Jimmy Savile, all public traces of him were removed, including his gravestone in a Scarborough cemetery, a plaque outside his former flat and a footpath sign in the same town, a statue of him outside a leisure centre in Scotstoun in Glasgow and his name on an inscription on a wall of Leeds Civic Hall.[29]

The textuality of archives can hide their meaning

Archives are mainly texts and as a result they suffer from the weaknesses of all such objects: their words and format can conceal their meaning. Documents can be silenced in plain sight. The first problem of texts is often recognised as being the need to discover which is the original and so what should be the focus of scholarly investigation. We can explore this difficulty by looking at how literary scholars have sought the 'original' of Shakespeare's *King Lear*. In the absence of a manuscript play script, they had to rely on two early printed texts: a quarto edition of 1608 and the 1623 First Folio. These texts differed from each other and scholars believed that

neither of them represented Shakespeare's authorial work. Beginning in the eighteenth century, they began to conflate the two texts in order to produce the definitive version. More recently, literary scholars have regarded this as an anachronistic approach and have argued that the two texts were, in fact, two separate plays. The 1986 Oxford edition includes both the 1608 and 1623 texts. Not to be outdone, in 1989, Michael Warren produced four texts of *Lear*, the 1608 and 1623 editions, a quarto of 1619 and his own parallel text of the 1608 and 1623 versions.[30]

While manuscript scholars are familiar with this problem of multiple and variant texts, archivists, on the whole have not had this problem because archives are normally unique. However, in 2016, Amanda Bevan and David Foster claimed to have discovered that page 2 of William Shakespeare's will (of 1616) was a survivor of an earlier, 1613 text.[31] Well, if we have four *Lears*, we can probably cope with two wills.

In the paper era, archivists knew where their records came from – their authenticity is protected by a chain of custody and issues as to which is the correct version rarely arise. This is not true in the digital era as can be seen from the notorious case of Barrack Obama's birth certificate. Obama was born in Hawaii and his birth was recorded there. However, many people were unwilling to accept a black man as president of the United States and developed claims that he was born in Kenya. Originally, the Department of Health in Hawaii released a printout from a database showing a short form of Obama's birth certificate. This did not satisfy critics and so a copy of the long form of the certificate was released in the form of a PDF. The new document was immediately attacked, partly because the PDF contained layers which, it was alleged, was a proof of forgery. Let us hear Andrew Prescott on the subject:

> the controversy is driven by a maniacal form of close reading of documents that is suspicious of almost every feature of an archival record. The rules and conventions that govern the use of documentary evidence, such as the role of certified copies, are overturned and disregarded. Yet this debate reflects the conventions of historical criticism by focussing on the status and characteristics of primary documents. However, this documentary analysis has become destabilised and unhinged to the point of lunacy, because of the effects of making the birth certificates available in digital form. The authenticity of the digital copies can only be shown by their provenance and in a digital environment it is easy to point to technical flaws that might suggest doubts about the document's veracity.[32]

The historian Lara Putnam has described how the move to digital has accelerated the sort of data gathering that historians were already doing and has facilitated the development of transnational history. However, this has come at a price. As she observes, 'in terms of discipline-wide transformation, shifting the outer bound of the possible matters less than shifting the center of the easy'.[33] Her observation, which is most pertinent to a book on silences, is that, while there is a wealth of resources available to scholars in wealthy institutions in the global north, the same is

not true of those in poorer institutions or in poorer countries.[34] Moreover, there is a real danger that scholarship will focus on what has been digitised and will ignore material that can only be accessed by a physical trip to an archive, effectively silencing much of the archive. As Tim Hitchcock observed:

> Without serious intent and political will – a determination to digitise the more difficult forms of the non-canonical, the non-Western, the non-elite and the quotidian – the materials that capture the lives and thoughts of the least powerful in society – we will have inadvertently turned a major area of scholarship, in to a fossilised irrelevance.[35]

The real silence of the archive

For many archival thinkers, the archive consists of texts. It is tempting to blame Derrida with his firm views on texts for this, but, however, Nicholas Royle suggested that in many of Derrida's texts 'the oral, the audile, the acoustic dimension is fundamental'.[36] Of course, the emphasis on texts goes back to Jenkinson with his view that records essentially relate to transactions and are, by their nature, textual. As Stanley Griffin notes, in Jamaica, where the oral tradition is vital, the National Archives does not have fully developed archival programmes for audio visual records. As Michael Piggott writes, when archive theorists do write about oral cultures, they like records to be firmly linked to something tangible – ceremonies, or things like rock art or even knotted string.

In this section, we will argue that the most significant silence of the archive is that even those records that originally had a degree of liveness and were intended to be spoken are now seen as dead texts to be read in silence and not as words to be heard. Doing this, we believe affects their validity and distorts our ability to interpret them. We take our cue from performance studies in which the conviction runs deep that to record or document a performance is to destroy or, at the very least, contaminate it. As Peggy Phelan observed, 'performance cannot be saved, recorded, documented, or otherwise participate in the circulation of representations of representations: once it does so, it becomes something other than performance'.[37]

A similar view is expressed by Stanley Griffin in Chapter 4, where he argues that the essence of the oral traditional form cannot be confined to paper, box and reading room.

As late as the seventeenth century, there was a hierarchy of value of speech, manuscripts and print. This becomes clear from the sermon which Archbishop Laud preached just before he was executed in 1645. Laud wrote out a text of his speech, not to read but as an *aide memoire*. He said that he had not read out his manuscript exactly but had kept close to it. He expressed concern that his words should not be misreported and asked John Hinde to take down a transcript of the sermon as spoken. Consequently, there were probably two manuscript versions – Laud's original text and Hinde's verbatim transcript.

As soon as Laud had been executed, the puritan Henry Burton published an attack on him, establishing the primacy of speech. He argued that Laud could not be said to have preached because he was reading the text verbatim, nor to have prayed because he was reading from his paper.

The sermon was subsequently printed with the title:

> The Arch-bishop of Canterburie his speech, or, His funeral sermon preached by himself on the scaffold on Tower-hill on Friday the tenth of January, 1645, upon Hebrews 12, 1, 2 also, the prayers which he used at the same time and place before his execution /all faithfully written by Iohn Hinde, whom the archbishop beseeched that hee would not let any wrong be done him by any phrase in false copies.

However, the printed text was incomplete – it omitted Laud's complaint about the way he had been treated by Parliament. We know this because a copy in the Bodleian is annotated 'corrected from the original'. The history of Laud's sermon illustrates the perilous journey of his words from manuscript back to memory, from memory to speech and from speech to manuscript and then printed text.[38] But, as Burton argued, the spoken word had primacy.

Records lie somewhere on this continuum. Some are partial transcripts of spoken words; ancient oral history from a distant past. For example, Holger Schott Syme has demonstrated that witness statements used in trials in England in the sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries were taken down in writing by JPs or their clerks. These statements were not necessarily exact transcripts of what the witness said, but edited versions. He quotes Lord Chief Justice Coke's aphorism *in lectione non verba sed veritas est amanda* (in reading, it is not words but the truth that is to be loved).[39]

The statements were then read aloud or 'performed' in court by the clerk. Syme quotes many examples of this; for example, at the murder trial of Richard Weston in 1616, the clerk read out 'the several examinations of divers witnesses taken before the Lord Chief Justice and others'.[40]

Performances of witness statements, depended, in Syme's words on a 'personator' speaking words recognisably not his own in order to produce the imaginary presence of something or someone personated. While vividness was of key importance in this representational effort, it nevertheless had to be tethered to an enduring sense of reality – that the clerk and the witness to whom he lent his voice were not the same.[41]

Other records were written texts intended to be spoken out loud. Wills were written – in part at least – to be performed. They were frequently read out by the executor to the relatives of the deceased. The reading of the will is a literary and artistic trope. Shakespeare famously portrayed Mark Anthony's reading of Julius Caesar's will. A short story in *Household Words*, by Samuel Sidney tells the story of lawyer Rigors who, late in life, married Kitty Carter, an 18-year-old barmaid. When the lawyer died, his son by a previous marriage attended the reading of the will, only to discover that Kitty had inherited one of the old lawyer's best estates and an

income for life. According to the narrator, 'They say the look the [new] Squire gave Kitty was awful'.[42]

Occasionally, readings of wills appear in records. In 1865, James Cathrill and Edwin Dresch were tried at the Old Bailey for forging a will. The case turned on the existence of a second will that Cathrill claimed to have found in a chest of drawers. The reading of the will was described by one of the executors:

> I attended the funeral—the persons named in the will were all there—after all came from the funeral they partook of refreshment, and then without moving [from the room in which refreshments were taken], the will was produced and read—Cathrill was present—before the will was read, a question was put to the company generally, asking if they knew of the existence of any other will.[43]

The image of a family gathered round while a lawyer reads the will was a theme used by a number of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century artists, giving them an opportunity to portray the varied reactions – joy, disappointment, etc. of the relatives, Thomas Rowlandson's version is the most bizarre – the family are gathered round the coffin, dogs are barking and the ghost of the deceased peeps through the door.

We should not make too much of this. Most of the text of wills was highly legalistic and followed the formulae set down by legal writers. However, wills need to be read in the knowledge that they were intended to be spoken out loud and heard by the family. There was always a possibility of surprise, while the occasional personal comment or the gift of personal items – rings, swords, cups, etc. – can be seen as a spoken message from the dead to the living.

Until the era of cheap and universal postal systems and almost universal literacy, letters too could have a spoken, as well as a textual quality. Mail services developed in continental Europe from about 1600, while in England, Wales and Scotland, Charles I allowed his subjects permission to use the royal post for private mail from 1635.[44]

Until then, private citizens had to either rely on the services of individual bearers, friends or even strangers to deliver letters, or they could use carriers. There was an elaborate system of carriers in the late sixteenth and early seventeenth centuries who travelled from provincial towns to London. They normally journeyed on the same day each week and stayed at the same inns in London. Richard Quiney, who visited London on behalf of the town of Stratford on Avon and who wrote the only surviving letter to William Shakespeare stayed at the Bell in Carter Lane, where the Stratford carriers lodged. The rhythm of letter writing was determined by the schedule of the carriers.[45] But where letters were sent by carrier, contemporaries saw them as having a spoken quality. John Earle wrote in his 1628 *Micro-Cosmographie* that the carrier: 'Is the Vault in Gloster Church that conueyes Whispers at a distance: for hee takes the sound out of your mouth at Yorke and makes it bee heard as farre as London'.[46]

Letters were sometimes read out loud to those who could not read, while those who could not write could use the help of friends or scribes. Abraham Sturley, alderman of Stratford on Avon, wrote letters on behalf of his sister Elizabeth Quiney to her husband Richard in 1598. Equally, letters were shared with a wider circle than the addressee. Sturley was 'made partaker of the contents' of a letter from Richard to Elizabeth.'[47]

However, it was the individual bearers who really emphasised the spoken nature of letters in a world in which trust in orality was strong compared to writing.[48] Some letter bearers simply delivered a letter and awaited a reply. In other cases, the letter served to introduce and authorise the bearer to deliver an oral message. In other cases, the bearer would provide a written or oral message to the sender giving a report on the letter's reading.

Alan Stewart described how the young Francis Bacon who was a member of the household of Sir Amias Paulet, the English ambassador to the French king, was entrusted with carrying letters to the English court. His role was to deliver the letters and also a verbal message to the Lord Treasurer, Lord Burghley. He spent a day walking round finding the people to whom he had to deliver the letters and message. He arrived in London on a Tuesday and the next day, he reported to Paulet that he had delivered the letters but had not yet had an opportunity to deliver his message to Burghley. He was also able to report back that the letters had been well received – he had 'good words' from Burghley and gracious words from the queen.[49]

In some cases, letters did not accurately reflect the speech of those writing and were, in a sense, literary productions. Professor Robert McColl Millar examined some extraordinary letters from two men (Thomas Holden and Richard Taylor) from Lancashire who were transported from England to Australia in the first half of the nineteenth century. The letters are semi-literate, but, surprisingly, they show few traces of a Lancashire dialect. Instead, they show the influence of evangelical Christianity and the bible. *Doth* instead of *does*, which is not a Lancashire usage of that period is probably biblical in origin, while contemporary Lancashire usages, such as *thou* for *you* are not found. They also demonstrate the standard beginnings and endings to letters that were taught at the time. Letters began *Dear X* and ended with a variety of standard phrases such as *till time shall be no more*.[50]

Mediation asserted its own agency and those messengers, clerks and attorneys who read letters, witness statements and wills aloud had the capacity to produce a different effect from that intended by the original writers simply by the way they delivered the text. Ben Jonson the playwright worried about players 'who were too witty in another man's works, and utter, some times, their own malicious meanings under our words'.[51]

The whole experience of visiting an archive is designed to induce a spirit of reverence. Documents that are intended to be records of speech and that can best be understood when spoken are required to be read as texts, under notices proclaiming 'Silence' and consequently the performance of the archive is contaminated.

In Chapter 9, Swapan Chakravorty discusses in some detail the issues surrounding the use of oral history as evidence. Clearly, records that are recollections, such as witness statements, need to be treated with a degree of care since they are mediated

both through the memory of the witness and also through the questions asked by the interviewer. However, it is the performative aspect of records such as wills and early letters that were written with the intention that they should be read aloud that needs to be analysed critically.

Archivists have not yet followed the lead of book historians who are interested in reading and oral historians who have realised that aurality offers many benefits over transcripts. They should do so. Anisa Puri, Australian oral historian, said:

> As oral historians, we know how essential it is to listen to an interview in order to interpret it. By listening, we observe and interpret meanings that are often lost in an interview transcript or summary. Speech carries meaning—whether it's the quickening of the pace, the softening of a tone, or a pregnant pause. The cadence and emotional qualities of a voice offer important aural clues for us to interpret. Appreciating the importance of aurality extends into how we present oral history in creative and immersive ways too, whether it's via a website, podcast, digital story, art installation, audio walking tour, museum exhibition or heritage interpretation.[52]

Conclusion

We have described Michel-Rolph Trouillot's analysis of silences in the archive: that they are inherent in the writing of history and in the creation of archives and that silencing archives creates a power to define what is and what is not a serious object of research and therefore of mention.

While we fully accept Trouillot's argument, we have found that the ending of silences does not always have the healing effect that might be expected. We have observed that, despite popular belief, the marginalised are not the only people to suffer from silences. Moreover, the ability to silence has been a weapon used by states since at least Roman times and continues to be used to this day.

What we have discovered is just how visceral and political archival silences can be and that, in highly contested situations, the ending of silences does not necessarily resolve issues. We believe that the digitisation of records may favour scholars in the wealthier north and focus research away from the non-western and non-canonical. The move to digital records will increasingly raise issues as to what is an original and, indeed, what is an authentic record. Finally, we are increasingly aware that silences mean silences. That archival practices have turned records that were intended to be spoken out loud – to be performed – into texts and by so doing have robbed them of much of their meaning.

Notes

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21 Robert McColl Millar, 'The problem of reading dialect in semiliterate letters: The correspondence of the Holden family, 1812–16 and of Richard Taylor, 1840–1851', in Marina Dossena and Gabriella Del Lungo Camiciotti, *Letter Writing in Late Modern Europe* (Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company, 2012), 164.
22 Michèle Barrett and Peter Stallybrass, 'Printing, writing and a family archive: Recording the First World War', *History Workshop Journal*, 75 (2013), 6.
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24 Arthur Bradley, *Unbearable Life: A Genealogy of Political Erasure* (New York: Columbia, 2019), 21–44.
25 Bradley, 2–3.
26 Bradley, 89.
27 Bradley 91.
28 Bradley, 190.
29 BBC News, 9 October 2012, *Jimmy Savile's Grave to be Dismantled in Scarborough*, www.bbc.co.uk/news/uk-england-york-north-yorkshire-19,889,974
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41 Syme, 129, 131.
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43 Old Bailey Sessions Papers, 12 June 1865, www.oldbaileyonline.org/browse.jsp?div=t18650612–631.
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45 Stewart, 125–128.
46 Stewart, 122. The reference is to the famous Whispering Gallery in Gloucester Cathedral, which enables a whisper to be heard on the other side of the gallery from which the speaker is standing.
47 Stewart, 121–122.
48 Alison Wiggins, *Bess of Hardwick's Letters: Language, Materiality and Early Modern English Epistolatory Culture* (London: Routledge, 2017), 148.
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